

PROTECTION RISK ANALYSIS

RENK RESPONSE TO SUDAN CRISIS (JAN – DEC 2025)



Fig 1: New arrivals being received at the Wunthou reception site @UNHCR/Renk

SUMMARY

Since the conflict erupted in Sudan in April 2023, Renk County has emerged as a vital entry point for refugees, asylum-seekers, returnees, and third-country nationals escaping violence. Between January and December 2025, a total of 220,044 individuals fleeing entered through the Wunthou/Joda official border point and various unofficial crossing points, with around 54% of them being South Sudanese returnees.

Reports gathered at reception sites consistently emphasized assaults on civilians, coerced displacement, both physical and psychological torture, arbitrary detentions, separation of families, sexual violence, targeted killings of South Sudanese individuals, forced recruitment, property extortion, and pervasive trauma as the most common violations and dangers that incoming individuals faced during their journey.

The combined effects of these experiences have led to significant psychological distress for many newcomers, especially those with specific needs (PSNs) such as individuals with disabilities, older adults, unaccompanied and separated children, and households led by women.

Upon their arrival, individuals may either stay at the Transit Center (TC) or integrate into the host community. However, the strain on services and decreased funding, particularly due to the three-month halt of onward transportation in early 2025, have resulted in ongoing overcrowding at the TC, which accommodated 10,949 individuals as of December 2025, three times its designed capacity.

This context, combined with limited socio-economic opportunities and strained humanitarian services, has created and exacerbated multiple protection risks affecting displaced populations across Renk.

PROTECTION RISKS FACED IN SUDAN

1. Loss of Property and Documentation¹: Numerous refugees and returnees have lost vital belongings and civil documents while fleeing, whether due to extortion, forced confiscation, or the need to sell their possessions to meet basic needs. Significantly, nearly 50% of those arriving in 2025 reported having lost, misplaced, or being unable to bring their documents across the border. Lacking documentation, these individuals encounter challenges in adapting to life in the TC or host community, making them increasingly susceptible to fraud, exploitation, harassment, and limited access to services.

3. Child and forced family separation: Numerous people have reported being disconnected from their families during times of conflict or displacement. This risk is especially pronounced for those who are forcibly returned without the chance to collect their belongings or notify and depart with family members.

Unaccompanied and separated children were particularly impacted by forced returns from Sudan, where they were frequently taken against their will without any chance to find or communicate with their families. Arriving alone in South Sudan increases their vulnerability to neglect, exploitation, trafficking, abuse, and recruitment into dangerous or exploitative activities. Efforts for family tracing and reunification were initiated for many of these children, but progress was hindered by limited communication channels, poor cross-border coordination, and the ongoing instability in Sudan.

Between January and December 2025, a total of 86 unaccompanied and separated children (52 boys and 34 girls) were assisted by child protection organizations, including Save the Children, ADA, and War Child, at the Transit Center. Of these children, 7 underwent formal family reunification processes, while 79 were reunited with family members through community-based support systems within a month of their arrival

The separation of families leads to significant emotional turmoil and puts individuals—especially children, women, and the elderly—at risk of neglect, exploitation, trafficking, and abuse, along with challenges in tracing family members across borders.

4. Psychological/ emotional abuse and inflicted distress: The risk of detention, forced repatriation, and the potential loss or separation from family and belongings contributes to a significant level of psychological distress. This issue is exacerbated by the harsh living conditions in Sudan and the scarcity of support services, which maintain high levels of anxiety and uncertainty.

Children and teenagers enduring prolonged uncertainty, insufficient services, and extreme economic challenges have increasingly turned to negative coping strategies. These include engaging in dangerous or exploitative labor, taking on informal and unsafe jobs, and even traveling to different regions in search of food or assistance—actions that put them at risk of arrest, abuse, trafficking, and renewed conflict. Adolescent girls are especially at risk of early and forced marriages, transactional relationships, and sexual exploitation due to their limited access to education and livelihood opportunities. Boys, particularly those who are unaccompanied, face increased dangers related to unsafe movement, substance abuse, peer pressure, and recruitment into harmful activities. For many families, these detrimental coping mechanisms are desperate measures driven by the need for survival, a lack of viable alternatives, and inadequate humanitarian assistance.

¹ Related to the protection risk “Theft, Extortion, Forced Eviction, or Destruction of Personal Property” under the Global Protection Cluster nomenclature

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5. Gender-based Violence (GBV): In Sudan, women and girls have reported facing detention, forced labor, sexual exploitation, and forced marriage by both the RSF and SAF, along with physical abuse, trafficking risks, and significant psychological distress. The ongoing conflict has greatly disrupted vital services and social support systems, exacerbating economic conditions for women and girls, which severely restricts survivors' ability to obtain protection, seek help, and pursue justice.

PROTECTION RISKS FACED IN SOUTH SUDAN

6. Access to Justice²: From January to December 2025, a total of 692 individuals (78.5% men and 21.5% women) sought legal assistance. Although there has been a rise in awareness regarding rights and grievance mechanisms, access to justice is still hindered by a shortage of legal service providers, protracted resolution processes, and deficiencies within the formal justice system. As a result, numerous survivors of violations choose not to seek justice, which leaves significant issues unaddressed and heightens the risks of ongoing abuse or impunity.

7. Gender-based Violence (GBV): Gender-Based Violence continued to be a significant and ongoing protection issue throughout 2025 in Renk County, impacting women and girls in both displaced and host communities.

Reported incidents encompassed various forms of violence. Psychological and emotional abuse was the most reported, making up 79% of all cases, followed by physical assault (41%), denial of resources (25%), and sexual violence, which included rape (14%) and sexual assault (8%). Furthermore, early and forced marriage (5%) was noted, emphasizing the growing pressure on families facing severe economic difficulties and social instability.

From January to December 2025, 99% of the reported incidents involved women and girls, with 95% of cases concerning individuals aged 18–59, while 5% involved children. This distribution by gender and age highlights the increased vulnerability of women and adolescent girls in displacement situations, where social protections are diminished and access to services is restricted.

Several underlying risk factors significantly contribute to these trends. Many women and girls fleeing Sudan arrive with a history of violence, trauma, and family separation. Once in Renk, the combination of limited job opportunities, overcrowded living conditions in the Transit Center, restrictive cultural norms, and stress related to displacement heightens the risk of GBV. Domestic violence is particularly prevalent, with women reporting experiences of emotional abuse, physical assault, and financial hardship within their households. These dynamics are often worsened by the breakdown of traditional support systems and the pressure on families adjusting to displacement.

Despite the magnitude of the issue, underreporting remained a significant concern. Survivors often encounter stigma, shame, fear of retaliation, and a lack of trust in formal reporting mechanisms. These obstacles prevent many from seeking timely help, leaving them exposed to ongoing harm and hindering the capacity of service providers to fulfill their roles.

8. Psychological/ emotional abuse and inflicted distress: The experiences of conflict, displacement, violence, and loss left a deep psychological imprint on affected populations.

² Related to the protection risk “Impediments and/or Restrictions to Access, to Legal Identity, Remedies and Justice ” under the Global Protection Cluster nomenclature

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Many accompanied children show significant psychological distress, as indicated by caregiver reports of behavioral changes such as nightmares, aggression, and withdrawal. These reactions stem from cumulative trauma due to conflict, displacement, violence exposure, and future uncertainty. The lack of child-friendly spaces and adequate psychosocial support leaves many children without the necessary support to process their experiences and regain safety.

Between January and December 2025, a total of 3,085 individuals received mental health and psychosocial support services, comprising 1,330 males (43%) and 1,755 females (57%). Services included clinical case management, counselling, psychoeducation, community-based activities, and recreational support for children. Of these, 660 individuals with mental disorders were given clinical management, while 1,606 accessed individual counselling and psychoeducation. There were also 13 recorded cases of suicides.

This emotional turmoil is exacerbated by difficult conditions in Transit Centers and host communities, characterized by overcrowding, poor food supply, lack of privacy, limited educational opportunities, and caregiver stress due to job loss and displacement. This environment undermines family dynamics, increasing children's vulnerability to violence, neglect, and harmful social norms. Limited mental health and psychosocial support services, a shortage of professionals, and stigma prevent access to necessary care, leading to negative coping strategies like substance abuse, domestic violence, child labor, and early marriage.

PROTECTION ENABLERS AND CHALLENGES

- 32 protection partners (including GBV, Child Protection, HLP, and MHPSS) supported displaced and host communities in 2025.
- A functional referral pathway allowed for timely identification, and support for individuals with specific protection needs.
- C4P, food, and non-food items were provided based on assessed vulnerabilities
- Family tracing, reunification, and communication services facilitated reunification throughout South Sudan.
- Integrated Health and Protection services in the eastern corridor
- Community engagement initiatives included awareness sessions, group PSS, community dialogues, and skills training aimed at mitigating protection risks.
- Capacity-building efforts for humanitarian partners, local authorities, and community leaders
- Protection assessments and monitoring informing program design, advocacy, and prioritizing at-risk groups.
- Onward transportation support allowed for the safe movement of over 10,000 refugees and returnees.
- 1,008 households were integrated in Abukadra, contributing to early solutions and alleviating congestion in temporary sites.
- Significant funding limitations resulted in the downsizing of protection programs and a decrease in operational capacity.
- Reduced personnel and mobility diminished field presence and restricted the coverage of prevention activities, particularly in the eastern and southern corridors.
- A lack of case management staff and specialized services, in relation to the scale of needs, led to delays and unaddressed protection issues.
- Limited facilities and overstretched services obstructed effective responses for individuals needing immediate or specialized assistance.
- Unresolved cases and extended waiting times heightened vulnerability and contributed to new protection risks.
- Resource shortages created obstacles to achieving sustainable, long-term, and durable protection outcomes for affected populations.

PARTNERS: Agency for Child Relief Aid (ACRA), Agency for Technical Cooperation and Development (ACTED), Africa Development Aid (ADA), Agenda for Relief and Development Initiative-South Sudan (ARDI-SS), Community Engagement Network (CEN), Community in

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Need Aid (CINA), EqualLife Africa (ELA), Ebony Women for Development Organization (EWDO), Humane Aid For Community Organization (HACO), Hope Africa South Sudan (HASS), Humanitarian and Development Consortium (HDC), International Medical Corps (IMC), International Organization for Migration (IOM), International Rescue Committee (IRC), The Israel Forum for International Humanitarian Aid (IsraAid), Jesuit Refugee Service (JRS), Lutheran World Federation (LWF), Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF-B), Norwegian Refugee Council (NRC), Oxford Committee for Famine Relief (OXFAM), Polish Humanitarian Action (PAH), Plan International, Relief International (RI), Save the Children International (SCI), South Sudan Red Cross (SSRC), South Sudan Women United (SSWU), United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA), United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR), United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF), War Child Alliance (WCA), World Food Programme (WFP), World Vision International (WVI)

This report was compiled through household-level profiling of returnees and refugees from Suda and application of the Protection Analytical Framework as designed by the Global Protection Cluster.

Contacts: Christine Salinas -Associate Protection Officer - salinasc@unhcr.org